



Tesla Model S upgrade

Tesla Model S being one of the highest-rated electric cars ever gets an upgrade <http://digit.in/teslas2>



HTC 10 leaks

HTC's upcoming flagship phone leaked which was announced on 12th April, the promo video involves an early sneak peak. <http://digit.in/htc10leak>

INPUT DEVICES

From punch-cards to virtual hands, Input devices have come a long way. Let us find out how.



The original source of inspiration for the QWERTY layout keyboards

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When asked to picture a computer, here is possibly nobody who will do so without including the ubiquitous keyboard and mouse. In fact, many of us would probably recall the peripheral first and the rodent later, upon hearing the word “mouse” - a quick google search will reveal how true this is. But computers weren't invented with input devices in mind, atleast not the ones we use now. With the ease of gliding our hands on our touchscreens or directly talking to our devices, it is very easy to forget the evolution of input devices in the

last century since computing devices were introduced. From punchcards to motion detection, let us see how we arrived here.

Just the right buttons

Key punches were around since as early as the 1800s in the form of Jacquard loom cards. Although there were other earlier ways to input information into a computing device like switches and dials, the keypunch and the punch-card methods were the first to have widespread usage for entering, storing and retrieving data. Around 1890, Herman Hollerith developed the first key punch device to tabulate the results of the 1890 Census in the USA. Since the census had 80 Questions, the key punch cards had 80 columns - a

number that carried his legacy in the form of 80 column computer screens for decades as well as the company he created, which later became part of IBM.

A step further, multiple punches could represent letters and numbers, which were also written on top of each column so that the cards could be read normally by eye. Re-programming or re-typing involved removing and rearranging cards or sometimes inserting entirely new ones into the sequence.

Derived mainly from the teleprinters and key punches of the yesteryears, keyboards made inputting information a very simple task of re-keying the statement compared to the complete removal and reinsertion of cards in the punchcard system. The initial design was inherited from typewriters as the QWERTY layout, which was never really changed although alternatives, like Dvorak layout, claim better speed and lower fatigue. In fact, there are a number of features about the current layout that are obvious shortcomings, like the single handed typing of many common words (was, were), left handed dominance, letters frequently used together not placed close etc. In spite of all these, the alternatives didn't really catch on.

Actually, there are vestiges of the keyboard's usage as a pre-mouse era input device that are still evident on most present day keyboards. Case in point - the scroll lock; Have you seen anyone actually using their keyboard to scroll anymore? Another example is the System Request (SysRq) key, from mainframe days.